STERLING

"PILOT"

Written by

Ken Cuperus

ACT ONE

1 INT. HOUSE - STUDY - NIGHT 1

CLOSE ON a window, as a blade slips in through the frame to slide along the base, tripping the lock latch. The window opens, and a THIEF IN A BLACK SKI MASK climbs in

The thief clicks on a penlight, and directs it towards a painting on the wall of what appears to be a STUDY. The figure removes the painting to reveal a WALL SAFE underneath. As the thief begins to turn the combination dial, a nearby floor lamp suddenly CLICKS ON, to REVEAL:

WILLIAM STERLING (mid/late 50's; dapper, clean cut, confident, looking bespoke in a three piece suit) sitting comfortably, legs crossed on a leather study chair.

THIEF
Who--?

STERLING
William Sterling, private investigator. My services were solicited by the victim of one of your previous robberies.

The thief looks back towards the open window.

STERLING (CONT'D)
Running is pointless, as is that ridiculous ski mask. I already know who you are. Harold Grey.

The thief pulls up his ski mask to reveal his face.

CLOSE ON - Sterling's LAPEL PIN, which is a tiny camera.

2 INT. TECH VAN - NIGHT 2

The inside of the van is decked out with SCREENS and TECH like a mini COMMAND CENTRE. A YOUNG WOMAN -- (This is SUMMER; mid 20's, sharp, vibrant, and fashionable) -- is looking at a monitor screen, showing the feed from the lapel camera.

SUMMER
We have a confirmed visual.
Sterling was right, It's Harold.
You owe me twenty bucks.

A MAN -- (This is GREG; 30's, intense, focused, and calculated) -- steps up behind Summer to have a look.

GREG
Okay, call it in. And don't gloat.

3 INT. HOUSE - STUDY / INT. TECH VAN - INTERCUT 3

BACK ON Sterling, as he stands, straightens his vest.

STERLING
Well, this has been--

The thief suddenly pulls a gun. With no hesitation, Sterling reaches out and grabs his wrist, twisting it, causing the gun to fall to the floor. Sterling kicks it away.

Sterling continues to twist his wrist, driving the thief down to his knees, in pain.

STERLING (CONT'D)
Now then, while we wait for the police to arrive, shall I tell you exactly how I knew who was under that mask?

ON Summer and Greg in the van, watching...

SUMMER
I love this part.

BACK ON Sterling.

STERLING
Don't get me wrong, you did a commendable job covering your tracks -- but you left a few small... a few...

Sterling looks uncomfortable. His face reddens, and he loosens his collar, as if struggling for air.

ON Summer and Greg in the van, listening in.

SUMMER
What's he doing?

GREG
Something's wrong.

BACK ON Sterling, as he releases the thief, to grip the edge of a desk to steady himself, his face a mask of pain. The thief sees an opening, rushes back through the window.

ON Greg and Summer in the van, looking horrified...

GREG (CONT'D)
Call an ambulance. I'm going in.

Greg throws open the back doors of the van...

4 INT. HOUSE - STUDY - NIGHT 4

Greg races in to find Sterling on the ground. He kneels next to him. We can hear distant POLICE SIRENS.

GREG
Sterling? Come on, stay with me.

Greg rips Sterling's shirt, and begins chest compressions.

DISSOLVE TO:

5 INT. STERLING AGENCY - AMELIA'S OFFICE - NIGHT 5

AMELIA CHO (late 40's/early 50's, stoic and authoritative, yet graceful) stands at the window of her office, looking out at the Toronto skyline, phone to her ear.

AMELIA
I see. Thank you, we'll make the arrangements.

A tear runs down her cheek. She wipes it away, and composes herself. Then she heads out of her office...

6 INT. AGENCY - MAIN ROOM - CONTINUOUS 6

...Into the main commonroom area of the Sterling Agency. Summer and Greg are waiting for her there.

AMELIA
It was a massive coronary. There was nothing we could've done. Harold Grey?

GREG
In custody. Police picked him up a few blocks from the house.

SUMMER
We turned over the video evidence.

AMELIA
Fine. Go home, both of you. There's nothing more we can do tonight.

SUMMER
What about you?

AMELIA
I have one more call to make. To William's son.

Summer and Greg both share a surprised look, then:

SUMMER
He has a son?

7 INT. MOTEL ROOM - NIGHT 7

A MAN (mid 30's) and a WOMAN (HANNA; early 30's) are getting hot and heavy in a motel room. They are still in the "undoing each other's buttons" phase, as we PAN OVER TO...

The BATHROOM DOOR, where a very uncomfortable looking BILLY STERLING (late 20's, a little scruffy, but undeniably handsome) is hiding, while trying to record video of the proceedings on his cell phone.

Unsatisfied with the angle, he begins crawling carefully across the floor, keeping low to the ground to get a better vantage point. The COUPLE are too preoccupied to notice.

Just then, Billy's phone RINGS. We see PRIVATE CALLER on his call display. He frantically shuts off the ringer.

HANNA
Is that yours? Mine's on vibrate.

MAN
So is mine.

They both sit up to see Billy there.

MAN (CONT'D)
What the hell?

BILLY
(awkwardly)
Housekeeping. Don't mind me, I'll get out of your hair.

HANNA
Billy?

MAN
You know this guy?

HANNA
He's crashing in the back of my boyfriend's bar.
(to Billy)
What are you doing here?

BILLY
You know, I've been asking myself that same question. I suspected you were fooling around on Cal, so I followed you here hoping I was wrong. I got in through the bathroom window. You really should pick a more secure location if you hope to get away with this kind of thing in the future.

HANNA
You really think Cal's gonna take your word over mine?

BILLY
Not a chance. He's crazy about you.
(waves phone)
That's why I took video.
(MORE)

BILLY (CONT'D)
At least I think I did, I'm not great with this--

Billy hits playback and we see and hear the pair getting hot and heavy.

BILLY (CONT'D)
Yep, I got it. Wow look at that resolution. I can see every mole... oh, dude, you should get this one checked out.

The Man hops of the bed, and advances on Billy.

MAN
Give me that phone, you son of a--

BILLY
Word of warning, I was trained in the art of Kung Fu by an actual Shaolin monk. Well, like three lessons, I was only there for a week, but I still-

The man punches Billy in the face, knocking him back a step.

BILLY (CONT'D)
Was that a wedding band? Who's the unlucky lady?

The man growls in anger, and swings again, but Billy is ready this time. He leans back to avoid the punch, then elbows the man in the ribs, taking the air out of him.

BILLY (CONT'D)
Welp, I'm gonna split, you two lovebirds have fun.

Billy exits out the door, as...

A TITLE CARD slashes across the screen, reading: **STERLING**

8 EXT. CAL'S BAR - NIGHT 8

A small Hipster Bar, called: WRY & GINGER

BILLY (PRE-LAP)
I'm sorry, Cal. I really am.

9 INT. CAL'S BAR - NIGHT 9

It's obviously late, only a few customers left finishing up their drinks, playing pinball on a few old school machines.

Billy sits at the bar, ice pack to his cheek, as the owner/bartender, CAL (late 20's; fiery red hair and full hipster beard) watches the video on Billy's phone.

CAL
I can't believe she was cheating on me. And with her yoga instructor? I didn't even think he was straight.

BILLY
Better to find out now then after things got too serious.

CAL
We've been together for three years. We have a dog together. Why didn't you tell me you suspected this was going on?

BILLY
I wanted to be sure first.

CAL
Well... I guess I owe you one.

BILLY
Letting me crash here is thanks enough. Always happy to help my oldest friend.

CAL
You mean your <u>only</u> friend. That's what happens when you disappear off the face of the earth for eight years.

BILLY
I didn't disappear, I was traveling.

CAL
Please. You were running away from your daddy issues. And for the record, I'm not 'letting you crash here,' I'm <u>renting</u> you the back room.

BILLY
About that. I'm a little light this month. A lot light.

Cal just shakes his head.

CAL
You've been back here for almost three months. What's the plan?

Billy doesn't answer.

CAL (CONT'D)
It's time to stop running, Billy.

BILLY
I'm not--

CAL
Does your dad even know you're back?

BILLY
He's a detective. Of course he knows. But he hasn't reached out.

CAL
Have you?

BILLY
I don't want to talk about this. I'm going to bed.

Billy gets up, and heads down the back hall, as Cal clangs a cowbell hung up behind the bar.

CAL
Closing early. My girlfriend's cheating on me. Last call, people!

10 INT. CAL'S BAR - BILLY'S ROOM - NIGHT 10

Billy enters his room, which is part living quarters, and part stockroom. He falls back on his pull-out couch bed. His phone rings, PRIVATE CALLER. He answers.

BILLY
Hello? Yeah, this is Billy.

Billy sits up, looking surprised.

BILLY (CONT'D)
Tell me what happened.

The screen goes black. We hear distant ORGAN MUSIC...

11 EXT. FUNERAL HOME - DAY 11

On the funeral home, as MOURNERS start to EXIT the building, and head for their cars. Amelia, Greg and Summer are among them. Amelia glances over, notices...

BILLY, sitting on a bench nearby, lost in thought.

AMELIA
You two go ahead, I'll catch up.

Amelia heads towards Billy, as Greg and Summer watch.

SUMMER
You think that's him?

GREG
Who, Sterling Jr? I guess so.

ON Billy, as Amelia approaches.

AMELIA
Hello, Billy.

Billy gives her a look.

BILLY
I recognise your voice. You're the one who called me to give me the news. Amelia, right?

AMELIA
You remembered.

BILLY
Yeah, I never forget a voice. Or a name. Or anything, really.

AMELIA
Your Father had the same gift.

BILLY
It's only a gift if there's nothing you'd rather forget. I take it you work for him?

AMELIA
Not for. With. I handle the business side of the agency. William was a brilliant detective, but he was a disaster when it came to bookkeeping.

Billy smiles.

AMELIA (CONT'D)
It was a lovely service. You should have come in.

BILLY
Was it an open casket?

AMELIA
No, he was cremated. Why?

Billy mulls this over.

BILLY
No reason, I guess.

AMELIA
When you're ready, I'd like you to come by the agency. I have something there for you.

BILLY
What is it?
(off her silence)
Come on, tell me, I don't like mysteries.

Amelia gives him an enigmatic grin.

AMELIA
Now that, I don't believe.

Amelia heads off, as Billy ponders this.

12 EXT. STERLING AGENCY - DAY - TO ESTABLISH 12

13 INT. STERLING AGENCY - MAIN AREA - DAY 13

Billy enters, looks around. He sees his Dad's big corner office next to the wall with WILLIAM STERLING INVESTIGATIVE SERVICES in big letters across it.

Amelia is in her office with Greg, and a man in an expensive suit, named DANIEL BANNERMAN (late 40's). Amelia spots Billy, and comes to her office door to greet him.

AMELIA
Billy, so glad you came. I'll be with you in a few moments.

Billy gives her a nod, and she head back into the office.

Billy spots Summer in her TECH AREA, and meanders up behind her to have a look at her MULTIPLE SCREENS, where she is scanning through several social media photos of a YOUNG WOMAN (This is TORI BANNERMAN; mid-20's -- think Paris Hilton with a smaller fortune, and no sex tape).

Billy MENTALLY DOWNLOADS the images, (which will be shown in a stylistic way that tells the audience he's memorising them.)

SUMMER
Hey, creepy. You just gonna hover, or are you gonna introduce yourself?

BILLY
Sorry. I'm Billy. Billy Sterling.

Summer turns around.

SUMMER
I know, I was just messing with you. Summer Lane. Tech specialist.
(sizes him up)
You have your Dad's chin.

BILLY
Do you think we could... not do the whole comparison to my Dad thing?

SUMMER
You also have his perpetual case of the grumps apparently.

Billy gestures to the screen to change the subject.

BILLY
I know this woman. Tori Bannerman, right? The hotel heiress?

SUMMER
That's right, daughter of Daniel Bannerman, owner and operator of Bannerman international, a chain of high-end boutique hotels. Who also happens to be our latest client.

Billy gestures to Amelia's office.

BILLY
Is that who's--

SUMMER
Yeah, his daughter is missing.

BILLY
That's terrible. But... Isn't this more of a police matter?

SUMMER
Typically, yes. But Tori has a history of this behaviour. Total party girl. She disappears for a few days with her rich friends, and eventually comes home on her own. He wants to keep the investigation small and discreet, so the press doesn't blow the whole thing out of proportion.

BILLY
How long has she been gone?

SUMMER
Almost a week. And she managed to pull a vanishing act from the penthouse suite of the Bannerman International Hotel, which is where she currently resides. Must be nice, am I right? 24/7 room service. I could get used to that.

Just then, Amelia, Greg and Daniel Bannerman, exit Amelia's office.

GREG
I promise you, sir. We'll find her.

DANIEL
I hope so. This isn't like the other times. She's never disappeared for this long before.

AMELIA
We understand, Daniel, you'll have our full discretion.

BILLY
Have you tried tracking her phone?

Everyone looks over at Billy. Greg looks annoyed.

DANIEL
I'm sorry, and you are--?

AMELIA
Daniel, meet Billy Sterling.
William's son.

Daniel looks impressed, comes over to shake hands with Billy.

DANIEL
Ah, good to meet you Billy. Very glad to hear a Sterling is still at the helm.

Greg bristles.

GREG
He's not.

BILLY
That's true, I'm --

AMELIA
Billy's been travelling. He's only recently returned.

Billy and Greg both give her a look. Daniel nods.

DANIEL
Well, make sure you bring him up to speed quickly.
(to Billy)
As for my daughter's phone -- We couldn't track it, because she left it behind.

Billy looks surprised by this.

BILLY
That's... strange.

GREG
No it isn't. She obviously left it because she didn't want to be found.

BILLY
I disagree.

AMELIA
Why is that?

BILLY
There's one common factor in every photo I've seen of Tori.
(MORE)

BILLY (CONT'D)
She always has her phone in her hand. It's her Her security blanket. She might turn it off to avoid being tracked, but she'd still take it with her... if she was able.

Summer scans through the photos.

SUMMER
Holy crap, he's right. She's got her phone in every single picture. Even in the pool. How?

BILLY
Eidetic memory. I can visually recall almost anything I've seen. It's kind of a nuisance.

A concerned Daniel turns to Greg and Amelia.

DANIEL
You see, I told you this time was different.
(to Billy)
I knew I had good feeling about you.

GREG
Let's not get carried away.

Daniel wheels on Greg.

DANIEL
(snapping angrily)
Carried away? My daughter is missing!

AMELIA
Daniel, we're all on the same team here.

DANIEL
(softening)
Look, Tori has a troubled past, no question. But this last year, she'd really straightened out her life, and she was finally ready to take a larger role in the family business. She's the one who asked me to manage the Toronto location... to learn the ropes. Why would she throw all that away? All that progress, for what?

AMELIA
We're going to find her.

DANIEL
I love my daughter more than anything. I can't lose her again.

OFF Billy, letting this sink in.

14 INT. AGENCY - AMELIA'S OFFICE - A SHORT WHILE LATER 14

Billy sits in the chair, across from Amelia.

AMELIA
That was impressive. We could use your talents around here

BILLY
I don't think Greg would like that.

AMELIA
Greg's a very capable investigator. But he's not your father.

BILLY
Neither am I. And I didn't appreciate you leading him to believe I work here. You put me on the spot.

AMELIA
Consider it an official offer then. Come work for the agency.

BILLY
As what, a detective? Are you kidding me, I don't have the first clue how to do that job.

AMELIA
I disagree. Sure you may be lacking some formal training, but the detail about Tori and her phone -- nobody else picked up on that, but you saw it immediately. That's what we need. It's what William wanted for you.

Billy's mood darkens at the mention of his dad.

BILLY
No, it's what he insisted on. He didn't give me a choice.

AMELIA
Well, you have one now.

BILLY
My answer is no.

AMELIA
Take some time and--

BILLY
You asked me to come here, and I did. But that's as far as this goes.

Amelia nods. Then she opens her desk drawer, takes out a manilla envelope and slides it to Billy.

BILLY (CONT'D)
What is this?

AMELIA
I don't know. William made me promise to give it to you if anything ever happened to him. And now I have.
(a pause)
If you change your mind--

BILLY
I won't.

Billy takes the envelope and EXITS.

15 INT. CAL'S BAR - DAY 15

The bar is still closed, chairs are up on tables. Billy sits at the bar, watching a VIDEO on his laptop. It's an ONLINE TMZ-STYLE INTERVIEW with Tori Bannerman, from the lobby of the Bannerman International Hotel. Several curious hotel guests are watching in the background.

TORI
...Just felt the time was right to make a change in my life, you know?

INTERVIEWER
So your party days are behind you?

TORI
I think that stuff was all blown out of proportion. I mean, I had some fun, and I made some headlines. But now, I just want to roll up my sleeves and get to work. I truly--

Billy pauses the video, as Cal comes in the front door.

BILLY
How did it go with Hanna?

CAL
It's over. And she's keeping the dog. Can you believe that?

BILLY
You hated that dog. You constantly complained about it.

CAL
You're missing the point.

BILLY
Whatever, come take a look at this.

Cal comes over to look at the laptop.

CAL
Sure you can borrow my laptop. How did you figure out the password?
(OFF Billy's look)
Nevermind. Is that Tori Bannerman?

BILLY
Yeah. But see this guy here?

Billy enlarges the image to focus on someone in the crowd. A MUSCULAR GUY, who seems fixated on Tori.

CAL
Kind of hard to miss. What about him?

BILLY
Look at the way he's staring at Tori.

CAL
A lot of people stare at her like that. She's super hot.

Billy gets a MEMORY FLASH (*a stylised rapid flash of something we've seen previously, that shows the audience how Billy's recall ability works*) of the other pictures on Summer's screen earlier... many with the same guy in the background.

BILLY
I've seen this same guy before, in other photos of Tori.

CAL
So he's a friend. Or a stalker. God knows she must have plenty of both. I hope that's my rent money in the envelope.

Billy looks down at the envelope.

BILLY
It's from my dad.

CAL
Aren't you gonna open it?

Billy gets up and heads for the front door.

BILLY
I'm heading out for a bit. There's something I want to look into

Cal looks at the envelope Billy left behind. We can see he's concerned.

16 EXT. HOTEL - DAY - TO ESTABLISH. 16

A few beauty shots of the Bannerman International Hotel.

17 INT. HOTEL - LOBBY - DAY 17

Billy enters the main lobby, through the revolving door. The Lobby decor is elegant but not extravagant.

Billy looks a bit out of place in T-shirt and jeans, as he glances around, not quite sure what he's looking for.

BILLY
What are you doing here, Billy?

Billy walks over to an elevator. He presses the button but nothing happens. He presses it rapidly a bunch of times. He's noticed by the FLOOR MANAGER (early 30's), a bubbly woman with an infectious smile. Her name tag reads Dee Dee.

DEE DEE
Excuse me. You look like you could use a little help.

BILLY
No, I'm good. But I think your elevator is broken.

DEE DEE
Actually, you need a keycard to activate all the elevators. It's for the security of our guests.

BILLY
Well, Dee-Dee... Maybe I should book a room then.

DEE DEE
Oh, sorry, more bad news. We're booked to capacity for the rest of the month. It's conference season. And one of our floors is closed for upcoming renovations, so we have even less rooms than usual.

Just then, Billy notices the MUSCLEBOUND GUY from the photos, in workout clothes, carrying a gym bag, as he heads across the lobby and down an adjoining hallway.

BILLY
Shoot. Guess I'm out of luck then. Thanks for your help.

DEE DEE
My pleasure.

Billy heads for the exit. He looks back, sees that Dee Dee is looking away, and quickly turns to dart down the hallway.

18 INT. HOTEL - GYM - DAY 18

Billy arrives at the GYM, and goes to open the door - but it's locked, and he has no key card.

A FEMALE GUEST exits, allowing Billy to slip in before the door can close and lock.

The gym is empty now except for the MUSCLEBOUND GUY (who we will soon know as VINCE, early 30's). He's lifting weights.

Billy sidles over, gives him a nod, and starts to pull the levers of one of the workout machines, as if he is also there to work out - despite the fact that he's in jeans, and has no idea how the machine works.

VINCE
Can I help you with something?

BILLY
Who me? No, just working on my pecs. And glutes. I'm going for a kind of pec-glute combo package.

VINCE
You always work out in your jeans?

BILLY
Hell yeah. Makes it that much tougher. I like to push myself.

VINCE
Well you're using that machine wrong. So before you hurt yourself, why don't you tell me the real reason you're here.

BILLY
Busted. Okay, the truth is I wanted to talk to you about Tori Bannerman.

VINCE
Cop or reporter?

BILLY
Neither. Just a concerned friend.

VINCE
Guess that makes two of us.

Vince goes to his bag, starts to take out a towel.

BILLY
So you know her well? Boyfriend?

VINCE
No. I work with her.

BILLY
Just work? Really? Come on, the way you look at her like she's the only person in the room? I know love when I see--

In a flash, Vince lunges, now holding a sharp blade -- a SILVER LETTER OPENER -- to Billy's throat.

VINCE
You made a serious mistake, pal.

BILLY
Funny... I was just thinking the same thing.

OFF Billy, eyeing the blade at his throat nervously.

END OF ACT ONE

ACT TWO

19 INT. HOTEL - GYM - DAY 19

Vince still has the letter opener to Billy's throat.

VINCE
Don't make me ask again. Who are you?

BILLY
Billy Sterling. Daniel Bannerman hired the Sterling detective agency to look into Tori's disappearance.

Vince let's Billy go, backs away.

VINCE
Mr. Bannerman mentioned he was bringing in a private investigator. Why didn't you just identify yourself.

BILLY
It does seem more sensible in retrospect. How about we start over.

Billy extends a hand, and Vince takes it.

VINCE
Vince Cavanaugh. Tori's personal bodyguard.

BILLY
Bodyguard. Of course.

VINCE
Sorry about before, I run a little hot sometimes. I wouldn't have actually slashed your throat.

BILLY
Good to know, I feel so much better. So what can you tell me about Tori's disappearance.

Vince gives him a look, not sure how much to share.

BILLY (CONT'D)
Look, I know you care about her more than you're letting on, okay? So why don't we help each other out?

Vince studies Billy, as he considers.

20 INT. HOTEL - SECURITY OFFICE - DAY 20

Billy watches as Vince scrubs through security camera footage. He finds what he's looking for.

VINCE
Here we go. Elevator security cam footage from the night Tori vanished.

In the footage, we see Tori, looking wasted as she leans on a MAN (This is WES; early 30's) for support.

BILLY
Who's the guy?

VINCE
Wes Byers. Up until a few weeks ago, he was Tori's boyfriend. But she suspected he'd been cheating on her, so she dumped his sorry ass.

BILLY
They look pretty cozy there.

Vince nods, not looking happy about it.

VINCE
Tori went to the club with some friends. I should have been there.

BILLY
Why weren't you?

VINCE
She didn't tell me she was going out. I can't protect her when I don't know where she is.

Billy can see this is eating at Vince.

BILLY
What makes you think Wes has something to do with her disappearance?

VINCE
He was the last one to see her. He left alone, about two hours later.

Vince brings up the CAM footage of Vince alone in the elevator, and then another CAM as he exits through the lobby.

BILLY
He's definitely alone. Were you the one who discovered she was gone?

VINCE
No. Tori was late for a meeting the next morning, so her Dad took hotel security up to check on her. None of this makes any sense.

BILLY
Why not? She's vanished before.

VINCE
Not like this. From the penthouse suite there's only two ways off that floor. The stairwell fire exit, which triggers a security alarm when the door is opened. And her private elevator which goes directly from the lobby to the penthouse.

BILLY
Who else has access to the elevator?

VINCE
Just housekeeping. But they would've shown up on the security cam. The only other person to go up to the penthouse was room service, bringing up a bottle of champagne, twenty minutes before Tori and Wes got back.

BILLY
Who put the order in?

VINCE
Wes. He called it in as he and Tori were leaving the club.

Vince brings up the footage of an OLDER STAFFWOMAN, wheeling a cart onto the elevator, with champagne and flutes on it.

BILLY
Not exactly threatening is she?

VINCE
She's been here thirty years, and still barely speaks english.

Billy looks around at Vince's desk. There's a pile of mail, some of it is addressed to Tori.

BILLY
You screen Tori's mail?

VINCE
Only recently. She's been getting some letters from a former employee with an axe to grind.

Billy picks up a few of the letters.

BILLY
These are all from the same person?

Vince brings a STAFF PHOTO of BRIAN HICKS up on the computer.

VINCE
Brian Hicks. A bellhop Tori had fired for sneaking into empty rooms to watch the porn channels on his breaks.

BILLY
You show these to the police?

VINCE
Tori wouldn't let me. If the cops open a file, the press would hear about it. She didn't want to end up on the front page again - even as the victim. Besides, the letters aren't threatening, the guy's just begging for his job back.

BILLY
I'm no expert, but it seems like he's still worth following up on.

VINCE
What do you mean you're no expert. You said you're a private detective.

BILLY
No, I said Daniel Bannerman hired the Sterling agency. I didn't say I worked there.

VINCE
But your name is Billy Sterling?

BILLY
Yeah. Family business. I'm just not part of it.

VINCE
Then why the hell are you here?

BILLY
I don't know, why are any of us here?

VINCE
(confused)
What?

BILLY
I know, deep right? So much to unpack. You really think it's the ex-boyfriend?

VINCE
Yeah. Wes is the guy, I know it.

Billy considers this.

BILLY
You know where I can find him?

21 INT. BAY STREET PARKADE - DAY 21

Wes Byers pulls up to his private spot in his BMW. He gets out, dressed in business attire.

BILLY
Wes Byers?

Wes turns to see Billy, who was waiting for him to arrive.

WES
Depends who's asking.

BILLY
What does that even mean? You either are Wes Byers or you're not.

Wes locks the car, and heads towards the door.

BILLY (CONT'D)
I'm a friend of Tori Bannerman.

Wes stops, gives him a once over.

WES
I doubt that.

BILLY
Her Dad's worried about her, you seen her around lately?

WES
I was out with her a few nights ago.

BILLY
You mean the night you went up to her penthouse suite with her. Funny, that's the last time anyone saw her.

WES
I don't know what you're insinuating, but she had too much to drink at the bar, so I helped her get home. I was a perfect gentleman.

BILLY
You ordered champagne to the room.

WES
So what?

BILLY
You said she had too many drinks at the bar, so feeding her more drinks back in her room seems like the opposite of gentlemanly behaviour.

Wes realises he stepped into a trap, but recovers quickly, giving Billy a dismissive look.

WES
I don't have time for this.

BILLY
You don't seem very concerned that she's missing.

WES
This is what she does, man. She likes to get away and party every now and then. If you were really her friend, you'd know that.

BILLY
Her dad seems to think she'd cleaned up her act.

WES
That's what all Dad's want to think, doesn't make it true. Look, when I left the hotel, Tori was still there. That's all I know.

Wes heads off. Billy looks at his car.

BILLY
I gotta get me one of these.

22 INT. HOTEL - LOBBY - DAY 22

Billy heads back through the lobby, and approaches Dee Dee who works at a desk. She looks up to see him coming.

DEE DEE
Oh, hello again.

BILLY
Dee Dee, how would you feel about giving me a private tour of one of your guest rooms?

DEE DEE
Well... I suppose that could be arranged.

Billy looks over at a PRIVATE ELEVATOR, separate from the bank of guest elevators.

BILLY
Maybe we could take that elevator over there?

DEE DEE
No, I'm afraid not.

BILLY
Let me guess, I need a keycard.

Dee Dee holds up her wrist to show the keycard dangling there.

DEE DEE
Not just a keycard, a master key. That's a private elevator.

BILLY
It wouldn't happen to go directly to the penthouse suite, would it?

DEE DEE gives him a curious look. Billy smiles.

23 INT. HOTEL - PENTHOUSE SUITE - DAY 23

Billy looks around the large furnished penthouse suit, which looks immaculate. Dee Dee watches, with interest.

DEE DEE
Poor Daniel. I knew Tori hadn't been around for a few days, but I didn't think it serious enough to warrant hiring a private investigator.

BILLY
I notice you call him Daniel, not Mr. Bannerman.

DEE DEE
He insisted. He treats his senior staff like family. In fact, I was the one he put in charge of training Tori when he brought her onto the team as his VP of hospitality.

BILLY
And did she... struggle with her new role?

DEE DEE
Oh, gosh no, she took right to it. I guess it's in the blood.

Billy smiles, looks around at the sparkling clean room.

BILLY
This place is immaculate.

DEE DEE
Housekeeping comes daily to do a thorough clean.

BILLY
Of course they do. So much for physical evidence. Unless...

Billy enters the kitchenette. He opens the Dishwasher, to reveal A CHAMPAGNE FLUTE inside.

BILLY (CONT'D)
Ha! They didn't check the dishwasher.

Billy uses a kitchen towel to pick up a glass, and inspects the rim. He spots a lipstick stain.

BILLY (CONT'D)
These are likely the glasses Tori and Wes used the night she vanished.

JUST THEN the suite door opens, and Daniel Bannerman leads Greg inside. Billy quickly wraps the glass in the towel.

DANIEL
Oh. Sterling, I didn't realise you were here.

Greg stares daggers at Billy.

GREG
That makes two of us.

BILLY
Just wanted to check on a few things. Dee Dee was kind enough to escort me up for a look around.

DANIEL
Well, you're in good hands. She's one of my top people. Since you're here, can you give me an update?

GREG
Yes, please Billy, do give Mr. Bannerman here an update.

Billy sees that Greg is laying a trap for him...

BILLY
Well... we do have some leads... lots of interesting leads...

DANIEL
Such as?

BILLY
Nothing we can share yet. We don't want to get your hopes up prematurely.

Daniel looks disappointed, then nods.

DANIEL
I expect a detailed report as soon as you have something more solid.

Daniel exits. Billy turns to Greg.

BILLY
I thought that went well.

OFF Greg smiling, but his eyes are telling Billy a different story. He's furious.

24 EXT. HOTEL - DAY 24

Billy and Greg EXIT the hotel, and Greg blows up.

GREG
Are you completely insane?

BILLY
Is that rhetorical, or...

GREG
Your name may be Sterling, but you don't work for the agency, and you can't just go traipsing into a potential crime scene on a whim.

BILLY
Traipsing? Seriously? Is that even a real word? I was trying to help.

GREG
I don't want, or need, your help.
(then; realising)
What is that? Did you just steal a towel from our client?

BILLY
Of course not. Well, technically I guess I did, yeah, but it was to protect the evidence.

Greg looks annoyed, as he takes the towel from Billy to see what's inside.

GREG
A champagne glass?

BILLY
Tori's ex-boyfriend ordered champagne to the room.

GREG
I know that.

BILLY
So you saw the elevator footage of Wes Byers?

GREG
Of course. Along with additional security footage from every camera in and outside the hotel.

BILLY
What about Brian Hicks. He's an employee that Tori fired--

GREG
We know all about him. He has no police record, no history of violence. Are you starting to get the picture here, Billy? We're professionals. We're not just... wandering around...

BILLY
You were going to say *traipsing* again, weren't you.

GREG
The point is we already have a strong lead we're following - So you can just head on back to whatever rock you crawled out from under, and stay the hell away from my investigation.

Greg heads off towards his car. Billy watches him go.

25 INT. CAL'S BAR - DAY 25

A few customers mingle. Billy sits at the bar with his head down, looking glum.

CAL
Dude, you're killing the vibe in here. If you're gonna sit there looking miserable, you should at least have a pint in front of you.

BILLY
I'm good.

CAL
What is it about the Tori Bannerman case that's got you so obsessed?

BILLY
She reminds me of myself in a way.

CAL
Not the looks obviously.

BILLY
Hearing her dad talk about how they were working through their issues, trying to make up for lost time... It got under my skin, I guess.

Cal nods in understanding.

CAL
So what about Tori's ex-boyfriend. You believe him when he says he had nothing to do with this?

BILLY
He didn't have any of the obvious tells that indicate someone is lying.

CAL
Maybe he's just really good at it.

Billy considers this.

BILLY
I do think he's involved somehow. But I don't know how to prove it.

CAL
What would your dad do?

Billy considers this for a moment...

BILLY
Hey, think I could borrow your car for a few hours?

CAL
Only if you promise to gas it up, I'm down to a quarter tank.

BILLY
You got it.

Cal tosses him the key, and Billy heads for the door.

26 EXT. CONDO BUILDING - NIGHT 26

Billy is parked outside Wes's condo residence, in Cal's tiny beater car. Judging by the empty coffee cup, and fast food wrappers, he's been there a while. On the seat next to him is paper with Wes's name and address -- and we see the same street number on the condo.

Billy watches as a WOMAN comes out to walk her dog. Then he sees a MALE FIGURE IN A YELLOW HOODIE head inside.

BILLY
This is a waste of time.

Billy starts the car, about to leave. The condo building garage door opens, and a familiar BMW emerges. (The windows are tinted so we can't see inside).

BILLY (CONT'D)
Wes's BMW. Okay, let's see where this goes.

The BMW heads down the street.

Billy waits for a few moments, then pulls out to follow.

27 EXT. CITY STREETS - NIGHT 27

A series of shots, as Billy follows Wes to a quiet, isolated part of the city, with very little traffic.

28 EXT. ISOLATED AREA - NIGHT 28

The BMW pulls off the road, into a WAREHOUSE DISTRICT.

A moment later, Billy pulls off as well, but warning lights on the dash blink on and the car starts slowing down.

BILLY
What? Why am I--
(sees empty gas gage)
Damn it.

Billy pulls off the road. Then gets out of the car, looks around trying to figure out what to do. He heads off at a jog, following the direction of the car.

NEW ANGLE - as Billy tries to find any trace of Wes's car.

BILLY (CONT'D)
Come on, where are you?

ON Billy rounding another corner. He sees a car coming, and ducks back beside the building. As the car passes, Billy gets a look at the driver: It's VINCE, Tori's bodyguard, looking ashen and panicked.

BILLY (CONT'D)
Vince?

Billy jogs in the direction Vince just came from.

NEW ANGLE - As Billy finally spots Wes's car, parked near a warehouse, the driver side door hanging open.

Billy approaches slowly and carefully, seeing that Wes is in the driver's seat, head down on the wheel.

Billy reaches in, takes him by the shoulder and pulls him back to see if he's okay.

BILLY (CONT'D)
Hey, is everything-- Oh crap.

Billy sees that Wes is dead -- with Vince's silver letter opener plunged into his heart.

As Billy backs away from the vehicle, and reaches for his phone, we hear a siren WHOOP, and a POLICE CRUISER pulls up.

TWO OFFICERS quickly climb out... both clocking the body.

BILLY (CONT'D)
Okay, so this is definitely not what it looks like.

The officers pull their weapons.

COP
Get on the ground, hands behind your head.

Billy does as instructed, blinking against the brightness of the glowing police cherry, as we....

END OF ACT TWO

ACT THREE

29 EXT. ISOLATED AREA - NIGHT 29

The area is now a crime scene swarming with UNIFORMED OFFICERS and a FORENSIC TEAM.

Billy is watching the show from the back seat of a POLICE CRUISER. A FEMALE POLICE DETECTIVE (this is VALERI JACKSON, 40's) approaches, and gestures to a COP

DETECTIVE JACKSON
Let him out.

The cop does as instructed. Billy eyes Jackson curiously.

DETECTIVE JACKSON (CONT'D)
Mr. Sterling, I'm Detective Jackson. Your father consulted on a few of my cases over the years. He was a smart man, sorry for your loss.

BILLY
You weren't at the funeral. I have a thing for remembering faces.

DETECTIVE JACKSON
I respected William -- but we weren't that close.

BILLY
Join the club. Oh, and for the record, I didn't kill Wes Byers.

DETECTIVE JACKSON
I know. You can thank your colleagues for that.

Billy looks over, sees Greg and Summer standing next to the TECH VAN, talking to an officer. Summer gives him a wave.

DETECTIVE JACKSON (CONT'D)
Pro tip? Next time you come across a crime scene, maybe don't get your fingerprints all over it.

BILLY
Right. Good note.

Jackson contemplates for a moment, then gives the cop a glance, before walking away. The cop starts to take off Billy's cuffs.

30 INT. STERLING AGENCY - MAIN AREA - NIGHT 30

ON SUMMER'S MONITOR SCREEN: We see DRONE FOOTAGE POV - Vince's car pulling up beside Wes's BMW in the secluded area.

WIDEN TO reveal Billy, Summer, and Greg watching.

BILLY
I can't believe this.

GREG
Why, you said yourself you saw Vince fleeing the scene.

BILLY
No, I mean I can't believe you have your own spy drone.

SUMMER
Right? Your Dad loved his toys.

On the video, we see Vince get out of his car. He bangs on the BMW window. He pulls open the door, then ducks inside the car - with the camera unable to see inside clearly.

A moment later, Vince backs away, then quickly jumps into his own car and drives away.

The drone repositions, and captures Wes inside the car, clearly dead. The image freezes on the body.

SUMMER (CONT'D)
That's when we called it in. You showed up a few minutes later.

BILLY
Why were you following Vince?

SUMMER
He has a history of violent behaviour that raised some red flags.

GREG
Stop. We don't owe him an explanation.
(to Billy)
This is the second time you've poked your nose in where it doesn't belong, Sterling. If it wasn't for us, you'd be sitting in a jail cell right now.

BILLY
I was following a hunch.

GREG
Why? You're not a detective. Nobody asked you to get involved.

AMELIA
Maybe it's time we changed that.

Everyone turns to see Amelia standing in her office doorway.

AMELIA (CONT'D)
A man connected to Tori has been killed. That's not a coincidence. She may be in more danger than we anticipated. So all of you, put your egos aside, and find the girl.

Amelia goes back into her office without waiting for an answer. Billy gives Summer a look.

BILLY
Wow.

SUMMER
Yeah. That's why she gets the big office. So you in or what?

Off Billy contemplating...

31 EXT. STERLING AGENCY - DAY (EARLY) - TO ESTABLISH 31

32 INT. STERLING AGENCY - DAY 32

Billy and Summer are watching HOTEL SECURITY CAM FOOTAGE. Billy rubs his eyes.

BILLY
This is torture. How do you sit and stare at screens all day?

SUMMER
I'm a millennial. I was raised by screens.

BILLY
Well it's not my style. We should get out there and shake some bushes, see what falls out.

SUMMER
That's not procedure.

BILLY
Screw procedure. Tori's out there somewhere, and every minute we sit around here, is another minute we're not finding here.

Summer gives Billy a look.

SUMMER
Love the passion. Really. But try to focus, okay. If you really have your Dad's eye for detail, you may see something we missed.

Billy sighs, turns his attention back to the screen.

ON VIDEO of an OLDER HOTEL STAFF WOMAN pushing a trolley with a champagne bottle on ice on it out of an elevator.

BILLY
I saw this piece already. The champagne was delivered eight minutes after Tori and Wes arrived at the room. And the employee returns in less than a minute without the cart.

SUMMER
Can I ask you a personal question?

BILLY
Go for it.

SUMMER
What happened between you and your dad?

BILLY
Oh boy. That's a lot to unpack, how much time do you have?

SUMMER
You're evading.

BILLY
Okay, fine. Our problems started after my mom died. Dad didn't know what to do with me so he settled on teaching me everything he knew about the art of criminology. He was determined that I was gonna follow in his illustrious footsteps whether I wanted to or not.

SUMMER
That... doesn't sound so bad.

BILLY
I was eight. I wanted to play video games and hang out with my friends on weekends, not study crime scene photos and learn how to memorise every detail in a room at a glance.

SUMMER
You never had a healthy relationship?

BILLY
I mean... there were moments. When I got my driver's license, dad let me buy a broken down 1983 Thunderbird. It was a total junker, needed to be rebuilt from the ground up. I was shocked when dad offered to help.

(MORE)

BILLY (CONT'D)
We spent an entire summer restoring it together. That was a high point.

SUMMER
Sounds amazing. You still have the car?

BILLY
Oh, god no, it's long gone. After our last big falling out, I sold it to fund my first trip to Europe.

Billy notices something on screen, that gets his attention.

BILLY (CONT'D)
Wait, that doesn't make sense.

SUMMER
What?

BILLY
Go back to her coming back on the elevator without the cart.

Summer scrubs back to the correct point in the video, as the woman re-enters the elevator.

SUMMER
Okay. What about it?

BILLY
I was on that elevator, and it takes exactly twenty three seconds to go from the penthouse to the lobby.
(off her look)
I know. I tried to shake dad's training, but it's like muscle memory.

Summer scrubs back the video.

BILLY (CONT'D)
Now watch the timecode, she's only on the elevator for a few seconds.

They watch to the point when the elevator doors open.

SUMMER
You're right. But how can that be, there's only two buttons on the panel. Lobby and penthouse.

BILLY
See if you can zoom in and isolate the moment she presses the button.

Summer zooms in, and we now make out that she INSERTS AND TURNS A KEY before pressing the L button.

SUMMER
Is that a key?

BILLY
Of course. Most hotels have service corridors that only staff can access. I wanna know what's on that floor.

Summer gives him a look.

SUMMER
What do you say we go shake some bushes?

BILLY
Thought you'd never ask.

They both head out.

33 EXT. HOTEL - DAY - TO ESTABLISH 33

Summer and Billy are talking to Dee Dee at her station.

DEE DEE
The residential suites have their own housekeeping services that operate out of that floor.

BILLY
What services exactly.

DEE DEE
Mostly just a laundry facility. Oh and the refuse collection room.

SUMMER
Refuse collection? As in garbage.

DEE DEE
Right. There's a garbage chute that dumps into the central refuse hub.

BILLY
And that chute extends to the penthouse level?

DEE DEE
Yes, actually it does.

Billy and Summer share a look.

34 INT. HOTEL - GARBAGE COLLECTION ROOM - DAY 34

Billy and Summer stand in a small room filled with a few large roller bins filled with garbage bags. One is placed directly beneath the mouth of a GARBAGE CHUTE.

BILLY
This garbage chute is just wide enough for a person to fit through.

SUMMER
Man, the smell...

BILLY
That's a good thing. Means they haven't emptied the bins recently.

Billy climbs into a bin, starts throwing bags out.

BILLY (CONT'D)
Come on, get in here.

SUMMER
I'm in charge of tech. You see any tech in there, you let me know. What are you even looking for?

BILLY
I have a theory about how Tori managed to vanish into thin air.

Billy stops, seeing something in the bottom of the bin that gets him excited. He pulls up, a long length of rope.

BILLY (CONT'D)
Yes! Damn, I'm good.

SUMMER
And humble too.

BILLY
If I'm right, Wes used this rope to lower Summer down the chute from the penthouse level.

SUMMER
You sure it was Wes? Maybe she came down the chute herself after he left.

BILLY
She never felt she had to sneak out before, she just left of her own volition, and didn't care who knew it. This was Wes, I'm sure of it. After he took the elevator alone to establish his alibi, I'd bet he came back in through a staff entrance to collect Tori. The cameras are mostly for guest security, they don't cover every inch of the building.

SUMMER
And the rope? Tori just had it lying around in her room?

BILLY
I don't know. And Wes can't tell us what with being dead and all. Which I'm assuming wasn't part of his plan.

Summer gets a TEXT MESSAGE.

SUMMER
It's Greg. We need to get back.

35 INT. STERLING AGENCY - MAIN AREA - DAY 35

Detective Jackson is giving Billy, Amelia, Greg, and Summer an update. She holds a note in a clear evidence bag.

DETECTIVE JACKSON
We pulled this off the printer memory in Wes's condo. It's a ransom note, demanding half a million in cash for the safe return of Tori Bannerman.

GREG
And the lab results on the champagne flute we found--

BILLY
I found.

GREG
Whatever. It tested positive for benzodiazepine.

AMELIA
That's a heavy sedative.

SUMMER
Which indicates she didn't go willingly.

BILLY
So this whole thing was just an elaborate cash grab? Why? The guy's a bay street banker.

DETECTIVE JACKSON
Doesn't matter how much money you make if you throw it all away at the blackjack table. We checked his finances, he was in serious debt.

AMELIA
So he kidnapped then tried to ransom off Tori, but was murdered instead.

GREG
By Tori's bodyguard, Vince Cavanaugh. Any luck tracking him down?

DETECTIVE JACKSON
We've cast a wide net, it's only a matter of time. But it's not clear how he fits in to all of this.

BILLY
Vince was screening Tori's mail. Maybe he intercepted the ransom note before it got to Daniel.

Greg considers this.

GREG
So he finds the ransom note, sets up a meeting, telling Wes he has the payoff money --

DETECTIVE JACKSON
And when Wes shows up, Vince Cavanaugh kills him.

BILLY
I think we're still missing something.

DETECTIVE JACKSON
Cavanaugh can fill in the blanks himself once he's in custody.
(to Amelia)
I'll need you to turn over everything you have on the case to me.

AMELIA
We don't work for you, Val. Our client is Daniel Bannerman.

DETECTIVE JACKSON
I've already discussed this with him, and he's agreed to cooperate. I'm sure he'll be in touch shortly.

The team shares a defeated look.

BILLY
I'm starting to understand why you and my dad weren't close.

OFF Detective Jackson's look...

36 INT. CAL'S BAR - DAY 36

Billy arrives back at the bar, and approaches Cal.

BILLY
Cal, you won't believe the day I'm having.

CAL
Let me guess, you got a call to come pick up your car from the police impound lot? No, wait, that was me.

Billy realises he forgot about the car.

BILLY
Oh, Man. I'm so sorry, I got distracted what with almost being charged with murder.

CAL
That's no excuse.

BILLY
Seriously?

CAL
Okay fine, it's a pretty good excuse. I added the tow charge to your rent bill. Also threw in a tank of gas.

BILLY
Totally fair.

CAL
By the way you have company. I told him you weren't here, but he insisted on waiting.

Cal gestures towards a Booth. Billy looks over to see a figure hunched down, with a ball-cap pulled down low. Billy heads over, and realises it's Vince Cavanaugh.

BILLY
Vince?

VINCE
Hey, Billy.

Billy lowers his voice.

BILLY
What the hell are you doing here? Every cop in the city is looking for you right now.

VINCE
I didn't kill anyone.

BILLY
There's drone footage that suggests otherwise. And I saw you fleeing the scene with my own eyes. You gotta turn yourself in before you make this so much worse for yourself.

Billy reaches for his phone, and Vince grabs his arm. He looks Billy direct in the eyes...

VINCE
I didn't do it, Billy. I was there, but I didn't kill Wes. Please... I need your help.

OFF Billy's hesitation...

END OF ACT THREE

ACT FOUR

37 INT. CAL'S BAR - BILLY'S ROOM - DAY 37

Billy leads Vince into the back room. Vince looks around.

VINCE
What is this? Do you live here?

BILLY
It's temporary. Just until I figure out my next move.

VINCE
If you say so.

BILLY
Okay, I don't think you're in any position to judge me. Besides, it beats living in a 10 by 10 cell, which is where you're likely headed.

VINCE
I'm telling you, I didn't kill Wes.

BILLY
But you intercepted the ransom note?

VINCE
What ransom note? I don't know anything about that.

BILLY
Wait, if you didn't know about the ransom demands, why were you there?

VINCE
I got a message from Wes asking to meet up. I figured it had something to do with Tori, so of course I went.

BILLY
Show me the message.

VINCE
I can't. It was on one of those anonymous apps that don't keep logs.

BILLY
Convenient. But he was killed with <u>your</u> letter-opener.

VINCE
That's why I'm so freaked out. It must've been stolen from my gym bag.

BILLY
If you're telling the truth--

VINCE
I am.

BILLY
Then maybe we can pull prints off the gym bag. Where is it now?

VINCE
Hotel security office. But I can't go back there. Maybe you could--

BILLY
Whoa... Let's not get ahead of ourselves. Why come to me?

VINCE
I did some research. Your dad solved a few big cases that kept innocent people out of jail. I figure maybe some of that rubbed off on you.

BILLY
You don't even know me.

VINCE
Well I don't have a lot of great options here. So you tell me... did I make a mistake coming to you?

Billy considers...

BILLY
I'll see what I can do, okay? Stay here, and don't talk to anyone.

Billy heads for the door.

38 INT. STERLING AGENCY - MAIN AREA - DAY 38

Billy is with Greg and Summer. Greg looks angry.

GREG
Have you completely lost your mind? You're harbouring a fugitive?

BILLY
I don't think he killed Wes. I just need some time to prove it.

GREG
If you're wrong -- and let's face it you probably are -- then you risk tanking the reputation of this agency. Everything your dad built.

Billy glances over to Amelia's empty office.

GREG (CONT'D)
Amelia's at the station, giving the cops everything we have on this case. So don't think she's gonna pull your ass out of the fire on this one just because of who your daddy was.

SUMMER
Dude... Not cool.

BILLY
Hear me out, okay? What if Wes wasn't alone in the car? The windows were tinted, maybe someone else was there.

GREG
And what, they killed Wes and left the scene before Vince arrived? That's pure speculation.

BILLY
You don't think it's possible that Wes was working with a partner?

GREG
Even if he was, why kill him and try to frame Tori's bodyguard?

BILLY
I don't know, you're the detective here, maybe you should, you know, detect that.

SUMMER
I think Billy has a point.

GREG
Who's side are you on?

SUMMER
I didn't realise there were sides.

Greg takes a moment to think it through.

GREG
You want me to pursue your theory? Fine. But first, turn Vince over to the police. Or I will.

Billy shakes his head, but capitulates.

BILLY
Fine. I'll take care of it.

Billy storms out, looking pissed. Summer turns to Greg.

SUMMER
Why are you being so hard on him?

GREG
Why are you giving him a pass? How much do we even know about him other than the fact his own father wanted nothing to do with him.

SUMMER
That's not fair. You don't know their history.

GREG
Here's what I do know. I don't like him, and I don't trust him.

SUMMER
Why, because it's his name up on the wall instead of yours?

Greg looks pissed, but he manages to keep his cool.

GREG
Track his phone.

SUMMER
Excuse me?

GREG
You heard me. I don't believe for a second he's planning to do as I asked.

SUMMER
Maybe he'll surprise you.

GREG
I guess we'll find out.

SUMMER
I don't like this. Amelia wouldn't--

GREG
I'm lead detective, it's my call.

Summer glares at him for a moment, then goes to her station, and starts working at her keyboard.

39 INT. HOTEL - LOBBY - DAY 39

Billy is making his way across the lobby towards the security office. His phone rings. He sees it's Cal, so he answers.

BILLY
Little busy here, Cal.

CAL
You've got a problem.

40 INT. HOTEL - LOBBY / INT. CAL'S BAR - DAY - INTERCUT 40

PHONE CALL: INTERCUT AS NEEDED.

Cal is in the bar, holding a court order. A few POLICE OFFICERS are chatting near the door.

CAL
The cops showed up with a warrant. It's like they knew Vince was here.

BILLY
Damn it. Greg didn't waste any time.

CAL
The warrant is for you too, Billy. Watch your back, okay?

Cal hangs up quickly, just before a cop looks his way.

41 INT. STERLING AGENCY/INT. HOTEL - LOBBY - DAY - INTERCUT 41

Summer is at her computer with Greg, watching a PHONE SIGNAL on a map. Her phone vibrates, and MOM comes up on call display. Summer shows Greg the phone screen.

SUMMER
It's my Mom. Gotta take it.

Greg frowns, but nods. Summer steps away.

INTERCUT WITH BILLY.

SUMMER (CONT'D)
Hello?

BILLY
You okay to talk?

Summer looks over at Greg, as she lowers her voice.

SUMMER
I had a feeling you'd call, so I changed my call display. It should buy us a few minutes. But if I call you Mom, play along, okay?

BILLY
You know Greg sold me out?

SUMMER
Yeah, he made me track your phone. He knows you're at the hotel. The police are on their way.

BILLY
This is ridiculous. I can read people, and I think Vince is innocent.

SUMMER
You also thought Wes was telling the truth when he said he didn't leave the hotel with Tori.

BILLY
That's true. So maybe I'm not as sharp as I thought. Or maybe....

From Billy's expression we can see something just clicked. He has a MEMORY FLASH: Dee Dee mentioning the hotel floor closed for upcoming renovations.

BILLY (CONT'D)
Of course. I think Wes was telling the truth?

SUMMER
Wait, so he didn't abduct Tori?

BILLY
I'll explain later, I have to go.

SUMMER
Okay, but power off your phone, or the cops'll be all over you.

Summer hangs up. END OF INTERCUT.

ON Greg, watching the signal on the screen. It DISAPPEARS.

GREG
What just-- The signal's gone.

SUMMER
Maybe his phone died.

Greg gives her a look, a little suspicious.

42 INT. HOTEL - LOBBY - DAY 42

Billy puts his powered off phone in his pocket. Just then he notices a MALE FIGURE in a YELLOW HOODIE enter the lobby, one hand in his pocket, holding something.

Billy is hit with a MEMORY FLASH: the same figure in the hoodie entering the lobby of Wes's condo building.

Billy walks over to try to see the face under the hood. And a MEMORY FLASH recalls the employee photo that Vince showed him in the security office.

BILLY
Brian Hicks. What's he--

Billy realises Brian is heading towards Daniel Bannerman, who is talking with Dee Dee, and doesn't notice Brian coming.

Brian starts to pull something from his pocket.

BILLY (CONT'D)
Oh no. Daniel look out!

Daniel turns to look, as Billy rushes towards Brian.

BRIAN
What are you--?

Billy DIVE TACKLES Brian to the floor, both of them sliding across the well-polished tiles. The object comes loose from Brian's hand. It's a letter.

DANIEL
Sterling? What the hell's going on?

Billy climbs to his feet, dragging Brian up with him, holding him in place, with his arm locked behind his back.

BILLY
Brian here was making a move on you.

BRIAN
I was just trying to give him a letter to give to Tori.

Dee Dee picks the letter up off the floor, scans it then hands it to Daniel who also reads it.

BILLY
I know you're working with Wes Byers. I saw you at his building last night.

BRIAN
I know him a bit from playing poker with some of the hotel guys. I went to see if he could help me reach out to Tori to apologise. I just wanted my job back, man.

Daniel gives Billy a look, hands him the letter.

DANIEL
It's an apology letter, like he said.

Billy glances at the note. He cringes, lets Brian go, and starts smoothing out his hoodie for him.

BILLY
Yep, you're clear. There we go. You're free to go, have a nice day.

Brian rubs his arm, as he walks off muttering. Daniel gives Billy a look - confusion mixed with annoyance.

BILLY (CONT'D)
Better safe than sorry, right?

DANIEL
Did you not get my message? The investigation's with the police now.

BILLY
I know. I'm just tying up a few loose ends.

DANIEL
Right. Well, I'm sorry our arrangement didn't work out, but I have to do what I think is best for my daughter. You understand.

BILLY
Of course.

Daniel shakes his hand and heads off, leaving Billy with Dee Dee.

DEE DEE
Poor Daniel. I hope Tori turns up soon, this is taking a toll on him.

BILLY
I'm sure the police will do everything they can. I just hope it's enough.

Billy takes Dee Dee's hand in his, gazes into her eyes.

BILLY (CONT'D)
De Dee, it's been an absolute pleasure. If anyone asks, you're getting a glowing review.

Dee Dee smiles, clearly charmed. She doesn't notice that Billy has removed the key card from her wrist and palmed it.

DEE DEE
That's so kind of you. But why would anyone ask you--

BILLY
Take care of yourself.

Billy heads towards the elevators. As he goes, he notices Detective Jackson arriving with a few UNIFORMED OFFICERS at her side. He turns his head away, hoping not to be spotted.

Billy steps onto the elevator, and the doors close - just before detective Jackson looks over in that direction.

ON Dee Dee, as she notices the key card is gone from her wrist. She looks down at the floor around her, thinking she must have dropped it.

43 INT. HOTEL - RENOVATION FLOOR - DAY 43

The ELEVATOR DOORS open, and Billy, holding the key card, ducks under the DANGER TAPE stretched across the threshold.

Billy is in a hall -- the only light source coming from the daylight through heavy plastic sheets covering the windows. There are building supplies stacked in piles, and electrical wiring hanging down from the exposed ceiling.

Billy makes his way down the hall, looking closely at the floor near hotel room doors as he passes.

He comes to a door, where he can see the thick dust cover has been disturbed. He listens at the door, but there's no sound. He presses the key card to the lock, and it opens.

BILLY
Thank you, Dee Dee.

Billy opens the door, and steps inside the dark room.

44 INT. HOTEL - RENOVATION FLOOR SUITE - DAY 44

Billy feels around for the lights, but there is no power. He carefully steps into the room, as his eyes adjust.

BILLY
Hello?

Billy listens -- and he hears a muffled groan. He moves deeper into the suite, towards the sound. It's mostly dark, as the windows are boarded over.

BILLY (CONT'D)
Is someone here? Tori?

Another muffled groan, louder this time.

Billy looks in the door that leads to the bedroom, and sees a figure on the ground. The figure groans, tries to move.

Closer inspection reveals it to be Tori, her arms and legs bound with heavy duct tape, preventing her from moving. Her mouth is also taped, and she looks to be in pretty bad shape. Weak, dehydrated, and makeup running from tears.

BILLY (CONT'D)
It's okay, you're safe now.

Billy removes the tape from her mouth.

TORI
Thank... you.

BILLY
I'll get some help.

Billy takes his (powered off) phone out of his pocket.

TORI
She's... she's crazy.

This stops Billy cold.

BILLY
She?

Immediately, Billy is flooded with a rapid series of MEMORY FLASHES -- little snippets of dialogue from the episode that now support a narrative he didn't know was there...

A look of total clarity crosses Billy's face.

BILLY (CONT'D)
Of course. How did I not see it.

We hear the creak of a floorboard, and Billy notices the look of horror that comes across Tori's face.

As Billy starts to turn, a two-by-four slashes through the dark to connect with the back of his head. THEN BLACKNESS.

END OF ACT FOUR

ACT FIVE

45 INT. HOTEL - RENOVATION FLOOR SUITE - DAY 45

Billy wakes up, and realizes he can't move.

BILLY
(Pained groan)
What--

He sees his hands and legs are now duct-taped, same as Tori. He sees his phone on the ground nearby (still off), and tries to get to it, but it's just out of reach.

He looks at Tori, and sees her mouth is taped again, but she is gesturing with her eyes to let him know someone is there.

BILLY (CONT'D)
I know you're there.

Nobody answers, but we hear a nearby scuffle.

BILLY (CONT'D)
I know it's you Dee Dee.

Dee Dee emerges from the dark corner to get in his face.

DEE DEE
You almost ruined everything.

BILLY
People know where I am, the police are looking for me. Mostly they want to arrest me, but at the moment that's a step up.

DEE DEE
They won't find you. Not for a few weeks when the renovations start. And even when they do find you, there's nothing that points to me.

She tears a strip of tape, about to put it over his mouth.

BILLY
Wait.
(OFF her hesitation)
I have proof that you and Wes were working together.

DEE DEE
You're giving him too much credit. He didn't even know the real plan.

BILLY
But why did you kill him? I know it was you -- I have proof.

DEE DEE
You're bluffing.

BILLY
I have a letter in my pocket that explains everything. Go ahead, look.

Dee Dee reaches into his pocket, and removes the apology note he took from Brian. Dee De squints to read.

DEE DEE
It's too dark.

BILLY
I guess you'll have to take my word for it.

DEE DEE glances down, notices Billy's phone...

DEE DEE
Or I can use the flashlight on your phone.

She smiles as she picks up his phone and powers it on.

46 INT. STERLING AGENCY - DAY 46

Greg and Summer both look surprised as Billy's phone signal suddenly comes back online on the monitor screen.

SUMMER
Signal's back.

GREG
Guess his luck ran out, huh? Pinpoint his location.

Summer looks concerned, but does as he tells her.

47 INT. HOTEL - RENOVATION FLOOR SUITE - DAY 47

Dee Dee smiles as she reads the note.

DEE DEE
I knew you were lying. Now, where were we...

Dee Dee drops the note, reaches for the tape.

BILLY
What did Tori do to deserve this?

Dee Dee looks at Tori as she explains.

DEE DEE
Everything changed for me the second Daniel's spoiled little princess here decided to sober up.
(MORE)

DEE DEE (CONT'D)
She was handed the job I was being groomed for. She took what was mine.

BILLY
So in return you steal her boyfriend, and conspire to murder her?

DEE DEE
Wes was just a useful tool. I knew about his gambling debts. He was in deep enough that he was desperate.

BILLY
So you convinced him this was a kidnap for ransom.

DEE DEE
It was surprisingly easy. I knew Tori was planning to go to the club that night, so I sent Wes there to slip a sedative into her club soda, to make her look sloppy. Nobody was surprised to see her in that state.
(to Tori)
Once a drunk, always a drunk, right?

Tori gives an angry muffled cry.

BILLY
I know Wes lowered her down the garbage chute to avoid the elevator security camera -- but the rope?

DEE DEE
I had it delivered directly to her room.

Billy thinks it through, until realizing...

BILLY
Of course. You stashed it under the champagne cart.

Dee Dee smiles.

BILLY (CONT'D)
But why kill Wes? And why frame Tori's bodyguard for the murder?

DEE DEE
I had to be sure nothing connected back to me.

BILLY
Yeah... about that. Detective Jackson -- please tell me you got all of that?

A figure steps around the corner, gun out. It's detective Jackson, flanked by a few COPS.

DETECTIVE JACKSON
I did.
(to Dee Dee)
Hands where I can see them.

DEE DEE
How--?

BILLY
I told you the cops were looking for me. And you led them right to me, when you turned my phone on.

Detective Jackson nods to an officer, who cuffs Dee Dee.

Billy looks over at Tori, gives her a smile. She nods her appreciation, as tears of relief flow.

48 INT. HOTEL - LOBBY - DAY 48

The lobby is now bustling with POLICE and EMT activity, as guests look on. Tori is being wheeled through on a stretcher, a saline bag hooked up to her.

She sees Billy who is also getting medical attention for his head. He waves off the EMR, and goes to Tori.

BILLY
Hey you. You're looking stronger already.

She manages a smile.

DANIEL
Tori!

Daniel Bannerman rushes over, and he and Tori share a hug.

DANIEL (CONT'D)
I thought I'd lost you. Thank god you're okay.
(to Billy)
I owe you everything. Thank you.

STERLING
Just take care of each other, okay? Not everybody gets a second chance.

Daniel nods, turns his attention back to his daughter.

DETECTIVE JACKSON
Sterling.

Billy turns to see Jackson nearby. He heads over to her.

DETECTIVE JACKSON (CONT'D)
We've cleared Vince Cavanaugh of all charges. He's being released now.

BILLY
Glad to hear that.

DETECTIVE JACKSON
What the hell were you thinking going up there alone like that.

BILLY
I was shaking the bushes.

DETECTIVE JACKSON
Shaking the bushes? Seriously. You almost got yourself and that young woman over there killed.

BILLY
But I didn't.

Detective Jackson shakes her head.

DETECTIVE JACKSON
You're your father's son, you know that?

BILLY
What do you mean?

DETECTIVE JACKSON
I mean that man broke protocol anytime it suited him. He was a constant pain in my ass. Do you know why I stuck with him?

BILLY
You're a glutton for punishment?

DETECTIVE JACKSON
Because at the end of the day he got results. Just like you did today.

BILLY
Sorry, I'm getting mixed messages. Are you saying you do approve or you don't approve of my actions?

DETECTIVE JACKSON
Time will tell.

She turns and walks away. Billy calls after her.

BILLY
I'm nothing like my Father.

Detective Jackson snorts a laugh, and keeps walking.

DETECTIVE JACKSON
Whatever you say, Sterling.

49 INT. STERLING AGENCY - DAY 49

Billy arrives back at the agency. Summer and Amelia approach to greet him. Summer hugs him, taking him buy surprise.

SUMMER
I'm happy you didn't die.

BILLY
Not as happy as I am.

AMELIA
Your father would be very proud of you, Billy.

BILLY
Maybe. But he'd never show it.

SUMMER
This is true.

AMELIA
How did it feel to close your first case.

BILLY
First?

AMELIA
Of many I hope. I believe this is where you're meant to be Billy.

SUMMER
I believe that too, if anyone cares.

Greg comes out of his office and approaches Billy.

GREG
What's going on out here. Saying our goodbyes?

AMELIA
Quite the contrary. I do believe Billy is considering taking me up on my offer to join the agency.

GREG
You can't be serious. The guy got lucky one time. He's a liability.

BILLY
Even I can't argue that.

AMELIA
You'll still be lead investigator Greg, this doesn't change anything.

GREG
It changes everything.

Billy extends his hand to Greg.

BILLY
Look... we got off on the wrong foot. Let's just start over, okay?

GREG
I quit. Effective immediately.

Greg goes to his office. Billy looks at Amelia and Summer.

BILLY
Aren't you gonna stop him?

AMELIA
He's more than capable of making his own decisions. And so are you.

Billy considers. Summer gives him a supportive arm squeeze.

SUMMER
Just give it a chance. Come on, your name's already on the door.

As Billy lets this sink in, we PULL OUT -- through the glass doors, where "WILLIAM STERLING INVESTIGATIONS" is etched into the smoked glass.

50 INT. WRY & GINGER - NIGHT 50

A few customers mill about. Billy and Cal are at the bar, tapping beer glasses in cheers.

CAL
I'm proud of you, dude. Finally following in your old man's shoes.

BILLY
You're just happy I can pay my rent.

CAL
That's as offensive as it is true.

BILLY
To be honest... I still don't know if I'm really cut out for it. I made some dumb mistakes.

CAL
So what? Tori Bannerman is alive because of you. Hey I don't suppose you could introduce us?

BILLY
Nice try.

CAL
Hey, it's your fault I'm single.
Oh, by the way...

Cal puts something down in front of Billy. The envelope from his Dad that Amelia gave him.

CAL (CONT'D)
You forgot this.

Cal goes to help a customer, leaving Billy to contemplate the still sealed envelope.

Finally he grabs it, and tears it open. Inside is a piece of paper with an address typed neatly across it. Taped below that is A SMALL KEY with a number on it.

51 EXT. STORAGE FACILITY - NIGHT 51

ON Billy, as he walks along a row of garage-style doors.

He stops at one of the doors, double checks that the number next to the door matches the number written on the key. He uses the key to open the PADLOCK, and slides the door up.

52 INT. STORAGE UNIT - NIGHT 52

Billy steps into the unit, and turns on a light -- TO REVEAL, a large tarp covering an unseen VEHICLE.

BILLY
No. No way. It can't be...

Billy pulls the tarp off the car to reveal... A metallic blue 1983 FORD THUNDERBIRD TURBO COUPE.

Billy stands back to look at his pride and joy, as a SONG begins to play, taking us back to...

53 EXT. YARD - DAY (FLASHBACK) 53

The Thunderbird is up on blocks, looking worse for wear, as a YOUNGER BILLY and his dad, WILLIAM STERLING work together on the engine, both covered in grease. Billy starts up the car and it purrs. Dad smiles, and pats him on the back.

54 INT. STORAGE UNIT - NIGHT - BACK TO SCENE 54

Billy leans against the car, and laughs at the absurdity of it all. The laughter gives way to tears of grief, as the full weight of his father's death finally hits him.

SMASH TO BLACK.

END OF ACT FIVE